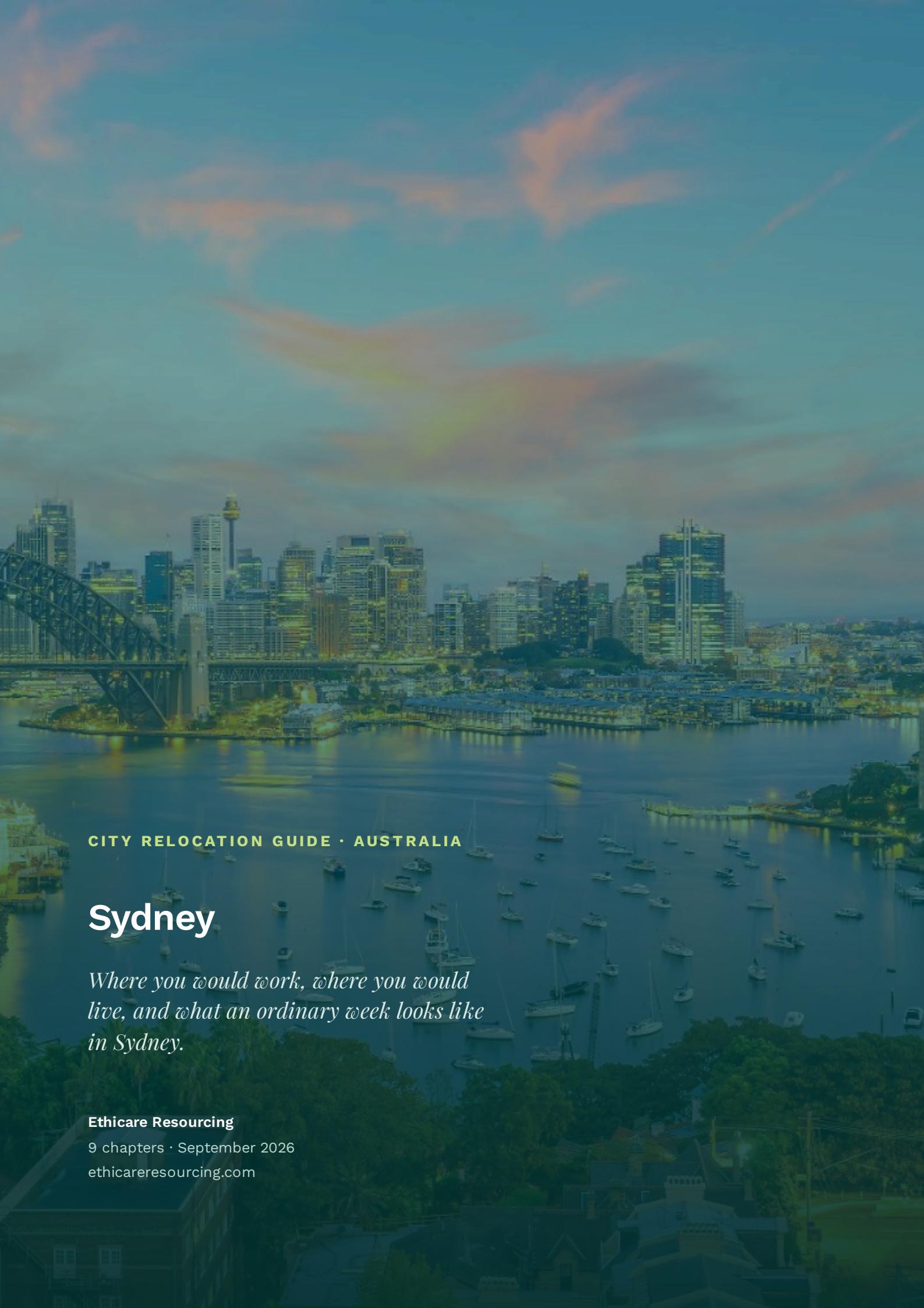


An aerial view of the Sydney city skyline at dusk. The Sydney Harbour Bridge is on the left, and the city's skyscrapers are illuminated. A faint rainbow is visible in the sky above the city. The water of the harbour is filled with many sailboats.

CITY RELOCATION GUIDE · AUSTRALIA

Sydney

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Sydney.

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters · September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

What's inside

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Sydney

Sydney Guide · Chapter 1 of 9



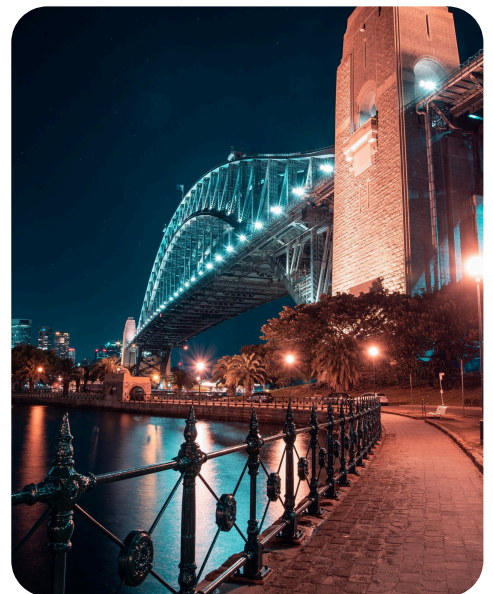
Sydney is the one Australian city that needs no introduction and the one that most needs an honest guide. The largest health system in the country, a spectacular setting, and housing costs that will shape every other decision you make. This guide is about making that trade with your eyes open.

A city built around water

Around five and a half million people live around a drowned river valley — which is why Sydney has no single centre but dozens, and why a journey of four kilometres can take forty minutes. The harbour, the beaches and the national parks that press in from three sides are not scenery here; they are the reason people put up with the rest.

For clinicians the draw is scale. New South Wales runs the country's largest public health system, and the greater Sydney share of it carries the deepest bench of tertiary and quaternary services, the biggest teaching hospitals, and specialist units that take national referrals. If your field is narrow, or you want to work at the very top of it, the density here is unmatched.

The honest cost is money. Sydney is one of the least affordable cities in the world for housing, and the gap between an inner-suburb life and an outer-suburb one is wider than in any other Australian city. Everything in this guide is written with that fact in the room.



The Harbour Bridge after dark

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest – but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

Sydney is the city candidates most often name first and research least. We will tell you plainly when the sums do not work, and which other city gives you the same career for a great deal less.

The city, in nine numbers

~5.5M

People in Greater Sydney – the largest city in Australia, and the largest health system with it.

~100

Beaches inside the metropolitan area, from Palm Beach in the north to Cronulla in the south.

~70 km

From the eastern beaches to the western edge of the metro area. This is a very large city.

Deepest

Bench of tertiary and quaternary services in Australia, spread across several local health districts.

Least

Affordable housing in the country, and among the least affordable in the world. Plan around it.

1 hr

To the Blue Mountains, a World Heritage escarpment that starts at the edge of the suburbs.

UTC+10

With daylight saving – long summer evenings on the harbour, and mild winters by any standard.

~40%

Of residents were born overseas. Whatever you left behind, there is a community here already.

2

Airports, once the western one opens fully – and the busiest domestic route in the country to Melbourne.

Six things you only learn once you're here

Rent decides everything

Where you live sets your commute, your savings and your weekends. Most newcomers rent smaller and further out than they expected, and adjust after a year.

The harbour is transport

Ferries are ordinary commuting on the same card as the trains, and the best twenty minutes of anyone's working day.

Distance is measured in time

Nobody says kilometres here. Four kilometres across the harbour can be forty minutes; twenty by ferry can be pleasant.

The beach is a routine

Ocean pools, dawn swims, the coastal walks. People genuinely do this before work, year-round, and it is the compensation for the rent.

Summer has teeth

Humid heat, and in bad years bushfire smoke that closes windows across the city. It is the part the postcards leave out.

There is no one Sydney

The east, the north shore, the inner west and the greater west are different cities with different prices, cultures and hospitals.

A note on Country

Sydney stands on the lands of the Gadigal and other clans of the Eora Nation, and Warrane is the name for the harbour's cove where the colony began. This is where the colonial history of Australia starts, and the city carries that weight.

Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings, and health services work in partnership with Aboriginal community-controlled organisations. Take the cultural induction seriously.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all about Sydney specifically. Topics true across the state – regional New South Wales, the state health structure – sit in the [New South Wales guide](#). Anything true of Australia generally – Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools – lives once in [Moving to Australia](#).

If you read nothing else, read [Why Sydney](#) for the full case – and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Cost of living](#), because in this city the money question comes before the suburb question.

Why Sydney

Sydney Guide · Chapter 2 of 9



Sydney needs no selling, so this chapter does the useful job instead: what the city actually gives a working clinician, what it takes back in rent and commuting — and when we'd point you interstate.

The argument

Scale, and the setting. New South Wales runs the largest public health system in the country, and Sydney holds the deepest concentration of it — major teaching hospitals across several districts, quaternary units that take national referrals, and research institutes attached to them. For sub-specialty work, fellowships and academic pathways, the density of opportunity here is unmatched in Australia.

Then the city itself, which at its best is genuinely extraordinary: a working harbour you commute across, a hundred beaches, ocean pools, coastal walks, and a mild climate that makes all of it usable most of the year. Pay follows NSW awards and enterprise agreements — we quote no figures here and will walk you through the current agreement instead.

Largest

Public health system in Australia

~100

Beaches inside the metro area

1 hr

To World Heritage wilderness

A typical week

A ferry commute across the harbour, which never quite becomes ordinary. A tertiary list with the equipment and the team to match. A swim at an ocean pool before a late start, or the Bondi-to-Coogee walk after one. Friday night somewhere in the inner west that would be a destination restaurant in a smaller city. Saturday at the beach with half the city; Sunday in the Blue Mountains or the Royal National Park, an hour away and completely quiet.

The honest counterweight: a proportion of that week is spent travelling, and a significant proportion of your income goes on housing. People who love Sydney accept both. People who resent them are usually happier elsewhere.

The ordinary evening version of the harbour – which is most of them

Sophie's insight

Sydney is the city everyone names first, and the one where I most often ask people to do the arithmetic before they commit. If your career genuinely needs the biggest system in the country, it is worth it – nowhere else in Australia has that depth.

But if what you actually want is a tertiary job, a house and a short commute, Brisbane or Adelaide will give you all three, and Sydney will give you two at most.

Sophie Careem Founder & CEO, Ethicare Resourcing

When we'd point you interstate

The housing maths

The least affordable city in the country. Buying near an inner-city hospital is out of reach for most clinical salaries, and renting takes a large share of take-home pay.

The commute

A city of 70 kilometres across with congestion to match. Affordable housing and inner-city work rarely coexist, and the difference is measured in hours a week.

Competition

The biggest system attracts the most applicants. Training posts and sought-after roles are genuinely competitive in a way smaller systems are not.

Summer extremes

Humid heat, and bushfire smoke in bad seasons. The western suburbs regularly run several degrees hotter than the coast.

It can be transactional

A big, busy, expensive city where people work long hours. Building a social life takes more deliberate effort than in smaller places.

Where we'd steer you instead

If you want tertiary work with housing that still adds up, read [Brisbane](#) – the closest thing to Sydney's career with a livable price.

If you want the deepest system but not the cost, [Melbourne](#) is the direct comparison – comparable depth, meaningfully cheaper.

If regional New South Wales appeals, the [NSW guide](#) covers the coastal cities and inland centres, many with strong incentives.

In our experience

Sydney suits clinicians who want the ceiling as high as it goes – the sub-specialty depth, the research links, the sheer scale. We're equally plain about the housing maths with everyone; the people who love Sydney decided the city was worth planning around.

Sydney at a glance

Sydney Guide · Chapter 3 of 9

Before the practical chapters, orientation. Sydney has no single centre — the harbour and the national parks split it into distinct cities that happen to share a name, a train network and a housing crisis. Knowing which one you are moving to matters more here than anywhere else in Australia.

The four Sydneys

The east

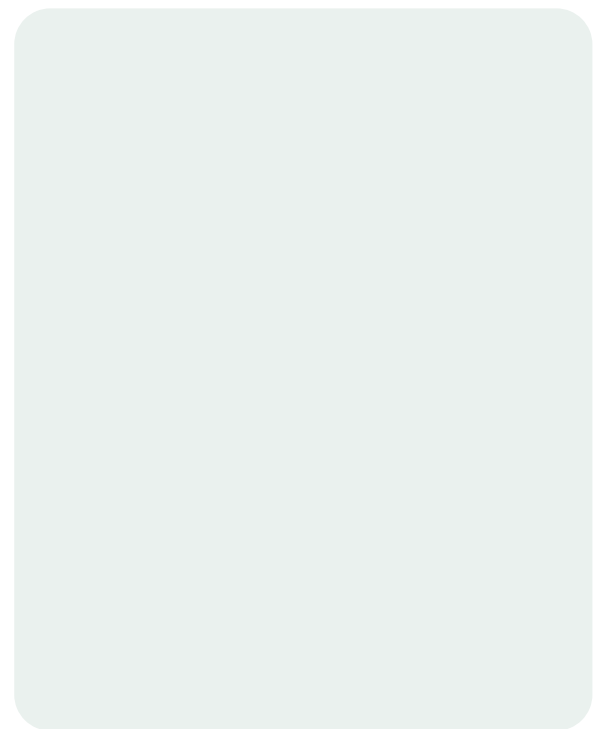
From the CBD out to the beaches: Surry Hills, Paddington, Bondi, Coogee, Randwick. Terraces, ocean pools, the coastal walk, and the highest prices in the country. Several major hospital campuses sit in this arc, which is what makes the eastern suburbs so competitive for clinical staff.

The north shore

Across the bridge: North Sydney, Chatswood, the leafy upper north shore, and the northern beaches running up to Palm Beach. Family territory, excellent schools, big trees, and a strong hospital presence. The beaches peninsula is beautiful and badly connected — a genuine trade.

The inner west

Newtown, Marrickville, Leichhardt, Balmain: Victorian housing, the best food in the city, a young and diverse population, and slightly more attainable prices. Well served by trains and light rail, and close to the central hospital cluster.



Where Sydney sits, with the straight-line distance to Newcastle and Wollongong

The greater west

Parramatta — Sydney's second CBD — and the vast western and south-western suburbs beyond it, where most of the city's population growth is happening. This is where housing is affordable, where the fastest-growing hospitals are, and where the summer runs several degrees hotter than the coast. It is also where a great many clinical careers are actually built.

A year in the weather

Temperate and mild by Australian standards, with humid summers and gentle winters that rarely need more than a jacket. Summer brings heat and humidity, storms, and in bad seasons bushfire smoke; the western suburbs run consistently hotter than the coastal strip. Autumn is the city's best season — warm water, clear air, fewer crowds — and winter is mild enough for the coastal walks to stay busy.

Summer

Dec – Feb

19–27°

Humid · storms · fire season

Autumn

Mar – May

15–23°

The best of the year

Winter

Jun – Aug

9–18°

Mild, bright, a jacket

Spring

Sep – Nov

14–23°

Jacarandas · warming up

Two practical notes. If you are looking west, check how a home handles heat — insulation, orientation and air conditioning matter far more twenty kilometres inland than they do at Bondi. And in fire season, smoke can close windows across the whole basin for days; people with asthma should plan for it.

Getting in and out

Sydney Airport sits unusually close to the city — about twenty minutes by train from the centre — and is Australia's busiest international gateway, with a second airport opening in the west. The Melbourne route is one of the world's busiest air corridors. By road, the Blue Mountains and the Central Coast are an hour, Wollongong an hour and a quarter down a spectacular coast road, and the Hunter Valley about two.

Words you'll hear in week one

WarraneThe Gadigal name for Sydney Cove — the harbour's original name

OpalThe tap-on card for trains, buses, ferries and light rail

The CoathangerThe Harbour Bridge, affectionately

Ocean poolA tidal saltwater pool cut into the rocks — there are dozens, and they are free

The North ShoreEverything across the bridge — a state of mind as much as a place

WestieOnce an insult for western-suburbs residents, now worn with pride

SchoonerThe standard beer size — smaller than a pint, and the correct order

ChockablockWhat the traffic is, most of the time, everywhere

Healthcare in Sydney

Sydney Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Registration is national; hiring here is district by district. Sydney holds the deepest concentration of clinical work in Australia, and it is spread across a metropolitan area large enough that choosing your district effectively chooses your life. This chapter explains the shape without naming employers.

How the system is organised

New South Wales runs its public system through local health districts — several of which cover metropolitan Sydney, divided broadly into the city and east, the north, the inner and south-west, and the greater west. Each district employs in its own right, runs its own recruitment, and covers a defined geography with a principal referral hospital and a network of sites around it. There are also statewide specialty networks, including children's health and forensic mental health.

Alongside the public districts sits the largest private hospital sector in the country, a substantial private imaging and pathology market, and major medical research institutes attached to the main teaching campuses.

Quaternary depth

The widest range of highly specialised services in Australia, including units that take referrals from other states and from the Pacific.

Districts, not one employer

Each metropolitan district hires separately. Where you apply determines your commute, your case mix and your colleagues for years.

The west is where growth is

Western and south-western Sydney carry the fastest population growth in the state, sustained hospital investment, and the most consistent recruitment.

One national register

Ahpra registration works everywhere in Australia. The process, English evidence and assessment live once in [Eligibility & registration](#).

FOUR SYDNEYS, FOUR EMPLOYERS

Each district hires separately, so the district you apply to sets your commute, your case mix and your colleagues for years. This is the single most consequential decision in a Sydney move – and most people make it by accident.

The city and east	The oldest teaching campuses and the most sought-after posts, with the housing cost and the competition to match. A superb place to work and the hardest place to arrive into cold.
The north	Large teaching hospitals across the harbour, a settled catchment and a strong research presence. The commute across the bridge is what decides whether it works for you.
The inner and south-west	Busy, complex and diverse, with major teaching hospitals and steady recruitment. A great many of the best Sydney careers are built here rather than east of the city.
The greater west	The fastest population growth in the state, sustained hospital investment and the most consistent recruitment – with housing thirty minutes from those campuses at a fraction of the eastern equivalent. This is where we point most people first.

Statewide specialty networks – children's health and forensic mental health among them – sit alongside the districts and recruit separately again. Registration itself is national: [Eligibility & registration](#).

What that means for a career

If you want to work at the very top of a narrow field, Sydney has more of those posts than anywhere else in the country – and more people competing for them. That is the honest trade of the biggest system: the ceiling is higher and the queue is longer. Fellowships, research appointments and highly specialised units

are all more plentiful here, and all harder to win.

The most useful advice we give candidates is to look west. The western and south-western districts run large, busy teaching hospitals with genuine complexity, they are where the state is investing, and they recruit consistently – while housing thirty minutes from those campuses costs a fraction of the eastern equivalent. A great many excellent Sydney careers are built out there.

One structural note: metropolitan Sydney is not classed as regional for skilled migration, which changes the visa arithmetic against much of regional New South Wales – see [Visas & the move](#) and the [NSW guide](#).

“

The highest ceiling in the country, and the longest queue. Both things are true.

The one-line version

What to ask at interview

Pay follows NSW awards and enterprise agreements – we deliberately quote no figures in this guide, and will walk you through the current agreement for your profession instead. What you can pin down at interview:

Salary packaging – public-health roles can package part of your pay pre-tax; ask how much and how to start it on day one

Which district and which campus – and whether you may be rostered across several sites

The roster reality – shift patterns, penalties, on-call frequency and how gaps get covered

Whether accommodation assistance or relocation support exists, which matters more here than anywhere

CPD – funded time and money, and what conference travel is covered

Research and teaching time, if that is part of why you came

Parking, and the commute at your actual shift times – inner-city parking is scarce and expensive

Professional indemnity – what the employer covers and what stays yours

Two things to do early

Start registration as soon as Sydney is on your shortlist – paperwork, not ambition, is what moves start dates. And decide your district before you look at a single rental listing: in this city the campus sets the commute, and the commute sets everything else.

Where clinicians live

Sydney Guide · Chapter 5 of 9



In Sydney this is the decision. The gap between an eastern-suburbs life and a western one is wider — in money, in commute, in what your weekend looks like — than in any other Australian city. Here is the map as we'd draw it over coffee, including the part most guides skip.

ON THE MAP

THE EAST

- 1 Surry Hills
- 2 Darlinghurst
- 3 Paddington
- 4 Randwick
- 5 Coogee
- 6 Bronte
- 7 Bondi

NORTH SHORE & BEACHES

- 8 Cremorne
- 9 Neutral Bay
- 10 Mosman
- 11 Chatswood
- 12 Killara
- 13 Northern beaches

THE INNER WEST

- 14 Newtown
- 15 Erskineville
- 16 Marrickville
- 17 Dulwich Hill
- 18 Leichhardt

THE GREATER WEST

- 19 Parramatta

● Parks & nature ● Beaches ● Landmarks

Shaded areas are the suburbs named in this chapter. Arrows point to places beyond the map edge, with the straight-line distance from the city centre.

Suburb boundaries © Geoscape Australia, CC BY 4.0 · Natural Earth

The east

Surry Hills, Darlinghurst and Paddington sit next to the central hospital cluster: terraces, restaurants, and a genuine walk-to-work life for the small number who can afford it. Out toward the coast, Randwick, Coogee, Bronte and Bondi put ocean pools and the coastal walk at the end of the street, with major campuses close by. This is the most competitive rental market in the country, and sharing well into your thirties is normal here rather than a failure.

The north shore and beaches

Across the bridge, the lower north shore — Cremorne, Neutral Bay, Mosman — gives harbour views, ferries and family life at eastern-suburb prices. The upper north shore around Chatswood and Killara is leafier, quieter and school-driven, with a large and long-established Chinese-Australian community and excellent food. The northern beaches are beautiful and genuinely isolated: no train line, one road in and out, and a commute that tests people.

The eastern beaches — the most expensive commute in Australia

The greater west – where the housing maths works

The inner west

Newtown, Erskineville, Marrickville, Dulwich Hill and Leichhardt: the best value inside ten kilometres, Victorian and Federation housing, and the strongest food culture in the city – Greek, Italian, Vietnamese and Lebanese layered over each other. Well served by trains and light rail, and close to the central hospital cluster. For clinicians without eastern-suburbs money, this is usually the answer.

The greater west, honestly

This is the part most relocation guides skip, and it deserves the opposite. Parramatta is Sydney's second CBD, with its own commercial centre, university presence and major hospital campus. Around it, the western and south-western suburbs hold the fastest population growth in the state, the biggest hospital investment, and family houses at a fraction of coastal prices – often thirty minutes from a large teaching hospital rather than ninety.

The honest trade-offs: summers run several degrees hotter than the coast, the beach is a genuine expedition rather than a walk, and the cultural centre of gravity is different – more suburban, more family-oriented, far more multicultural. For a great many clinicians, particularly those with children, the west is not the compromise. It is the sensible choice, and we say so plainly.

The honest comparison

Least

Affordable housing market in Australia

4 wks

Typical bond, lodged with the state authority

Share

Normal well into your thirties near the coast

If you want...	Consider	Because
Walk to the central campuses	Surry Hills, Darlinghurst	No commute at all – at a price
Ocean pools before a shift	Coogee, Bronte, Randwick	The eastern beaches, campuses close
Harbour and a ferry	Cremorne, Neutral Bay, Balmain	The best commute in the country
Value inside 10 km	Newtown, Marrickville, Dulwich Hill	Inner west – food, trains, terraces
Schools and space	Chatswood, the upper north shore	Leafy, established, family-shaped
A family house that adds up	Parramatta and the greater west	Big hospitals, real houses, sane prices

Renting itself – applications, bonds, rights, the documents that win a competitive inspection – works the same across Australia and lives once in [Living in Australia](#). Sydney-specific: go to inspections with every document ready to submit on the spot, and expect to apply for several properties before one lands. That is normal here and not a reflection on you.

Before you sign a lease

What is the commute to your actual campus at your actual shift times – door to door?

If you are looking west: how does the house handle 40-degree days? Insulation and orientation matter.

Is there a train, light rail or ferry within walking distance? Bus-only suburbs feel much further out.

Is it in the school catchment you need? Zones are checked by address [here](#).

Would a short lease first be wiser? Almost everyone re-chooses after their first year.

Getting around

Sydney Guide · Chapter 6 of 9



Sydney's public transport is better than visitors expect and its traffic is worse. The rail network is extensive, the ferries are a genuine pleasure, and the driverless metro is steadily changing the city. The rule here: live near a station, or accept the commute.

The network, in four parts

Opal

One tap-on card — or a contactless bank card — across trains, metro, buses, ferries and light rail, with daily and weekly caps and cheaper off-peak travel.

Trains

An extensive suburban network reaching most of the metro area, plus intercity lines to the Blue Mountains, the Central Coast and Wollongong. The backbone.

Metro

Driverless, frequent and expanding across the city — already reshaping which suburbs count as well connected.

Ferries

Ordinary public transport, on the same card, across the harbour and up the Parramatta River. The best commute in Australia, and not a tourist novelty.

Car-free life is realistic near a train, metro or ferry line — which covers much of the east, the inner west and the lower north shore. It is far harder in bus-only suburbs and on the northern beaches, where one road carries everything.

Driving here

Australians drive on the left. Sydney is the hardest Australian capital to drive in: a road network shaped by water rather than planning, heavy congestion, and an extensive toll network across the motorways and harbour crossings, so a toll account is essential rather than optional. Licence transfer and buying a car work the same across the country and live in [Living in Australia](#).

Two local notes. Hospital parking in the inner city is scarce and expensive — ask about staff parking at interview rather than assuming. And check your commute at the times you will actually travel: a route that takes twenty-five minutes at 10am can take an hour at 8am.

Ferries are on the same card as the trains — and comfortably the best of the network.

Distances that actually matter

From the CBD to...	Roughly	How
Surry Hills / Darlinghurst	10–15 min	Walk or light rail
The eastern beaches	25–40 min	Bus or light rail
Lower north shore	15–25 min	Ferry or train
Inner west	15–25 min	Train or light rail
Parramatta	~30 min	Train or river ferry
Northern beaches	45–75 min	Bus or drive — no train
Sydney Airport	~20 min	Train
Blue Mountains / Central Coast	~1 hr	Intercity train or drive

The takeaway

Choose your home by its station, not its postcode. In Sydney the difference between a well-connected suburb and a bus-only one is an hour a day, every day — and that hour costs more over a year than the rent difference that tempted you.

Cost of living

Sydney Guide · Chapter 7 of 9

This is the chapter that matters most in Sydney, so we will not soften it. This is the least affordable housing market in Australia and one of the least affordable in the world. What follows is the arithmetic, and the strategies that genuinely work.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Sydney against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

The headline

Highest

Housing costs of any Australian city

30–40%

Of take-home pay on rent is common here

West

Where the same salary buys a house, not a flat

The structural truth does not move: your housing decision determines your Sydney experience more than your salary does, and the east-to-west gradient is the single biggest lever you have.

What everyday life costs

WHERE A MONTH ACTUALLY GOES

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent is sixty per cent of the month – the highest share of any destination in this collection, and the reason this chapter exists.



Rent	61%
Groceries	15%
Entertainment	8%
Transport (Opal or fuel + tolls)	7%
Power & water	7%
Internet	2%

The line that decides it Rent · 61%

Every other line is ordinary; the rent line is the whole problem. That is also why it is the one worth strategising – the section below is about moving that segment, not the small ones.

The strategies that actually work

Look west, seriously
A family house thirty minutes from a large teaching hospital in the west costs a fraction of a flat near an eastern campus. This is the single biggest financial decision available to you here.

Share for the first year

Sharing well into your thirties is completely normal in Sydney. It buys you a year to learn the city before committing to a suburb — and most people move after that year anyway.

Use the transport network

A suburb on a train, metro or ferry line with no car at all can save more than a rent discount in a car-dependent suburb. Run both numbers before choosing.

Ask about accommodation help

Some employers offer relocation support or subsidised accommodation, particularly outside the inner city. It is asked for far less often than it should be.

Where the money comes back

What is free here is the point: a hundred beaches, dozens of free ocean pools, the coastal walks, the harbour foreshore parks, the botanic gardens and national parks at three edges of the city. A Sydney weekend can cost nothing at all and still be the best weekend available in Australia. Public transport is good enough to make a car optional in much of the inner city, which is thousands a year.

On the income side, public-health and not-for-profit roles here can salary-package part of your pay before tax — ask payroll on day one, because in this city it matters more than anywhere. How packaging, tax and superannuation work is national and lives in [Pay & conditions](#).

The bottom line

Do the arithmetic before you accept the job, not after you arrive. Work out what you can genuinely pay in rent, then look only at suburbs within that number and within a sane commute of your campus. If the two do not overlap, that is not a failure of planning — it is Sydney telling you something, and [Brisbane](#) or [Melbourne](#) may give you the same career for a great deal less.

Get today's numbers, and compare them to home

These are live and updated continuously, which is why we send you to them rather than competing with them. Put the city you are leaving in the other box.

[Numbeo cost-of-living calculator](https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/) (<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/>) — the most complete comparison tool, and the one most clinicians already use. Crowd-sourced, so read it as a ballpark rather than a quote.

[Expatisitan](https://www.expatisitan.com/cost-of-living) (<https://www.expatisitan.com/cost-of-living>) — the same idea with a cleaner side-by-side. Worth running as a sanity check when Numbeo looks off.

[Australian Bureau of Statistics](https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation) (<https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation>) — official, slower, and the one to trust on the direction of travel rather than any single price.

If what you find contradicts the judgement on this page, tell us. We would rather correct the page than defend it.

Food, coffee & the everyday

Sydney Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

Sydney's best food is not on the harbour. It is in the suburbs where people actually live — the Vietnamese south-west, the Lebanese west, the Chinese north shore, the Greek and Italian inner west — and eating your way around them is the fastest way to understand the city.

Where the city eats

Cabramatta, in the south-west, is one of the great Vietnamese food precincts anywhere outside Vietnam. Lakemba and Auburn cover Lebanese, Turkish and Afghan cooking, and come alive during Ramadan when the night markets run late. Chatswood and Eastwood on the north shore hold outstanding Chinese, Korean and Japanese food. The inner west layers Greek, Italian, Vietnamese and Portuguese along a few kilometres of Marrickville and Leichhardt.

Closer to the centre, Surry Hills and Potts Point carry the restaurant scene proper, and the CBD hides good Japanese and Korean food in basements. For everyday shopping: Woolworths and Coles everywhere, ALDI for the cheap basket, and excellent independent grocers and butchers in every one of the neighbourhoods above.

Coffee is a standard

Sydney takes coffee seriously without Melbourne's theology. Find your local in week one — the good ones have queues and no branding.

The markets

Carriageworks on Saturday for the serious cooks, Marrickville for value and variety, Paddington for the browse. Flemington for wholesale prices if you cook a lot.

Brunch is an institution

Weekend brunch here is a genuine social ritual, and Sydney arguably invented the modern version of it. Expect a queue and no bookings.

Beach food is its own thing

Fish and chips at the ocean pool, a coffee after a swim, a barbecue in a foreshore park — free gas, first come first served.

Flavours of home

With around four in ten residents born overseas, Sydney is the easiest Australian city in which to find whatever you grew up eating. Halal butchers across the west and south-west, kosher shops and bakeries in the eastern suburbs around Bondi, South Asian groceries in Harris Park and Wentworthville, African and Middle Eastern stores across the west, and Asian supermarkets in essentially every suburb. Very little needs ordering online.

The practical upside for newcomers is community rather than just ingredients: those shops sit alongside the associations, places of worship and weekend gatherings that turn a new city into a life. If you are arriving alone, that is the fastest route in.

The everyday rhythm

Sydney lives outdoors and early. Swims before work, coastal walks at dawn, park runs, and outdoor tables whenever the weather allows — which is most of the year. Summer adds the beach, outdoor cinema and long evenings; winter barely closes anything, though the water gets brisk. The city's calendar runs on Vivid's winter light festival, the New Year fireworks on the harbour, and a sporting schedule that fills most weekends.

The everyday, in one list

Learn one food suburb properly — Cabramatta, Lakemba, Chatswood or Marrickville.

Serious shop: Carriageworks or Marrickville markets. Cheapest: ALDI and Flemington.

Find your local coffee place in week one, and the nearest ocean pool in week two.

Say schooner. Book nothing for brunch. Accept the queue.

Harbour, beaches & the mountains

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Sydney's weekends are the compensation, and they are genuinely extraordinary. A hundred beaches, national parks pressing in from three sides, a harbour you can swim in, and a World Heritage escarpment an hour from the suburbs. Most of it is free.

The beaches

East: Bondi, Tamarama, Bronte, Coogee — linked by the coastal walk that everyone does at least monthly, with ocean pools cut into the rocks along the way. North: Manly, Freshwater, Curl Curl and up the peninsula to Palm Beach, quieter and better for surfing. South: Cronulla and the beaches inside the Royal National Park, where the crowds thin out entirely.

The ocean pools deserve their own mention — dozens of them, tidal, free, and used year-round by people of every age. They are the most democratic thing about this city.

Bondi at sunrise, before a day shift

The harbour

Take the ferry to Manly at least once a month; it costs the same as a bus and is one of the great urban journeys anywhere. Beyond that: Cockatoo Island's industrial heritage, the harbour beaches at Balmoral and Nielsen Park where the water is flat and warm, the Hermitage foreshore walk, and Sydney Harbour National Park's tracks around the headlands. The New Year fireworks are worth doing once, from a park with a picnic.

The mountains and the parks

The Blue Mountains begin an hour west: a World Heritage sandstone escarpment with the Three Sisters, canyons, waterfalls and hundreds of kilometres of walking track, plus mountain villages that are ten degrees cooler than the city in February. South, the Royal National Park – the world's second-oldest – has the coast track, cliff-top walks and beaches you have to walk into. North, Ku-ring-gai Chase holds Aboriginal rock engravings and bushland running down to the water.

NATIONAL PARKS ON THREE SIDES

The compensation for everything else in this guide: three ways out of the city, and a World Heritage escarpment or a coast track at the end of each. Most of it is free.

North, up the peninsula

Quieter beaches and better surfing the further you go – and the ferry, which costs the same as a bus and is one of the great urban journeys anywhere.

The city	Manly · by ferry	Curl Curl & Freshwater	Ku-ring-gai Chase
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West, into the mountains

A sandstone escarpment with canyons, waterfalls and hundreds of kilometres of track – and villages ten degrees cooler than the city in February.

The city	Blue Mountains · ~1 hr	The Three Sisters & the canyons
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South, down the coast

The world's second-oldest national park, then the Sea Cliff Bridge, then white sand and the quiet towns beyond.

The city	Royal National Park	Sea Cliff Bridge	Jervis Bay
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The east is the fourth direction and needs no rail: the Bondi-to-Coogee coastal walk, and dozens of tidal ocean pools that are free and used year-round by people of every age.

Further afield

The Hunter Valley

Two hours north — Australia's oldest wine region, and the classic Sydney weekend away.

The south coast

Down past Wollongong on the Sea Cliff Bridge to Jervis Bay's white sand and the quiet coastal towns beyond.

The Central Coast

An hour north by train — beaches, lakes and a much slower pace, popular for a weekend shack.

Ten weekends, to start

The Bondi-to-Coogee coastal walk, with a swim at each ocean pool

The Manly ferry, then the Manly-to-Spit walk back around the harbour

The Blue Mountains: the Three Sisters, then a canyon walk away from the lookouts

The Royal National Park coast track, or just the beaches you have to walk into

Ku-ring-gai Chase for the rock engravings and the water views

A Hunter Valley weekend, cellar doors and a long lunch

The south coast: the Sea Cliff Bridge, then Jervis Bay's white sand

Cockatoo Island and the harbour's industrial history

Balmoral or Nielsen Park for flat, warm harbour swimming

Vivid in winter, walking the harbour foreshore after dark

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Sydney. Statewide and regional topics live in the [New South Wales guide](#), and everything national in [Moving to Australia](#). When you're ready to talk about real roles here, [we're easy to reach](#) — and there's no pipeline waiting on the other end of the call.